SnipKeep: PRD and Spec

Nov 3, 2026 · Asher Wertheim · Status: approved, ready to build

Summary

SnipKeep is a tiny Windows app that saves every Win+Shift+S screenshot to a folder you pick, like macOS does. You set the folder once and forget about it. It installs in under a minute, needs no admin rights, uses no tray icon and sends no data anywhere.

It replaces the current PowerShell script in `pc-screenshot-saver` with a real installed program: its own name, icon, Start menu entry and uninstaller.

Problem and goals

On Windows 10, Win+Shift+S copies the snip to the clipboard only. To keep it, you open Snip & Sketch, click Save, pick a folder and type a name. That is 4 extra steps for every screenshot. macOS saves to a set folder by default.

The current script fixes this but feels like a hack. It shows as "Microsoft Windows Based Script Host" in Task Manager, its alerts say "Windows PowerShell", and it has no proper install or uninstall.

Goals

1. Zero extra steps per screenshot after setup.
2. Feels like a real, trusted Windows app.
3. Small and light enough that you never notice it running.
4. A clean, well-documented repo that works as a portfolio piece.

Success metrics

Metric	Target
Install to first saved screenshot	under 60 seconds
Steps per screenshot after setup	0
Installer size	under 2 MB
Memory while idle	under 30 MB
CPU while idle	0% (event-driven, no polling)
Data sent off the PC	none
Snips missed in a 100-snip test	0

Users and user stories

The main user is a Windows 10 or 11 user who takes many screenshots for work: PMs, ops, support, QA, designers. Many came from a Mac and miss its screenshot flow. They are comfortable

installing apps but do not want to configure much.

1. As a user, I want every snip saved to my folder automatically, so I never lose a screenshot.
2. As a user, I want to pick the folder once, so I do not think about it again.
3. As a user, I want the app to start with Windows, so it just works after a restart.
4. As a user, I want to open SnipKeep from the Start menu, so I can change settings without hunting for a tray icon.
5. As a user, I want to pause saving for a while, so private images I copy are not stored.
6. As a user, I want only real screenshots saved, not images I copy from a browser.
7. As a user, I want to be told only when something goes wrong, so Windows' own snip alert is the only one I see.
8. As a user, I want to uninstall it from Settings > Apps like any other program.

Scope

v1 does one job well: catch the snip, save it, stay out of the way.

v1 features

Feature	Detail
Auto-save	Every new clipboard screenshot saved as PNG to the chosen folder
Screenshots only	On by default. Skips images copied from browsers, Office and file copies
Duplicate guard	Skips an image identical to the last one saved
Settings window	Folder, file name pattern, start with Windows, screenshots only, pause
Open from Start menu	Launching SnipKeep while it runs opens the settings window
Pause / resume	One button in settings. Optional auto-resume after 15 min, 1 h or until restart, or stay paused until resumed
Start with Windows	On by default. Shows as "SnipKeep" in Task Manager > Startup
Error alerts only	Branded "SnipKeep" toast when a save fails, nothing on success
Installer	Per-user, no admin, Start menu entry, uninstall from Settings > Apps
Portable exe	Same app without installer, for people who prefer it

Later (v1.x)

- Sub-folders by month (`2026-11\`).
- JPG option to save space.
- Open the last screenshot with a hotkey.
- winget and Microsoft Store listing.
- Code signing to remove the SmartScreen warning.

Not doing

- Editing, markup or annotation. Snip & Sketch already does this.
- Cloud upload or sharing.
- Our own capture tool or hotkey. We use the Windows one.
- Screenshot history or gallery UI. File Explorer does this.
- macOS or Linux versions.

UX flows

The user sees SnipKeep twice: at setup and when they want to change something. The rest of the time it is invisible.

Install and first run

1. Download `SnipKeep-Setup.exe` from GitHub Releases.
2. Run it. One screen: "Install SnipKeep" with an Install button. No admin prompt.
3. On finish, SnipKeep opens the welcome window: "Where should screenshots go?" with the folder pre-filled as `Pictures\Screenshots`.
4. User clicks Change or keeps the default, then Done.
5. The window closes. A one-time toast says "SnipKeep is on. Press Win+Shift+S to try it."
6. On the first saved screenshot only, a toast says "First screenshot saved. Click to open the folder." This shows the user where files go. Later saves stay silent.

Daily use

1. User presses Win+Shift+S and selects an area.
2. Windows shows its own "Snip saved to clipboard" alert.
3. SnipKeep saves the PNG in under 1 second. No alert from SnipKeep.

Change settings

1. User opens SnipKeep from the Start menu.
2. The running copy shows its settings window. No second copy starts.
3. Changes save right away. Closing the window keeps SnipKeep running.

Settings window

- Status line: "Saving screenshots to D:\Shots" with a Pause button.
- Save to: folder path, Change, Open folder.
- File name: pattern with live preview, for example `Screenshot 2026-11-03 12.30.49.png`.
- Screenshots only: on / off.
- Start with Windows: on / off.
- Footer: version, "Quit SnipKeep" link, GitHub link.

Failure

- Folder missing or not writable: toast "SnipKeep could not save. Click to choose another folder." Click opens settings.

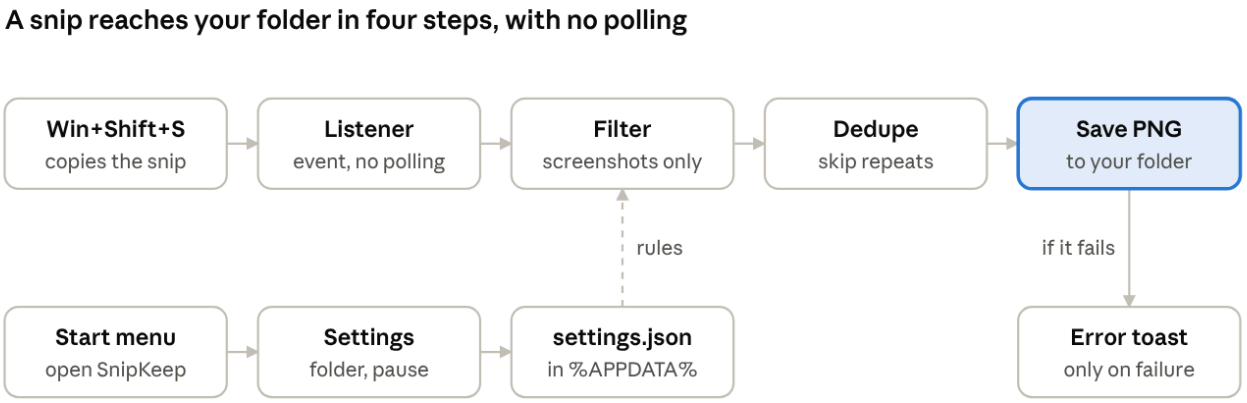
Uninstall

1. Settings > Apps > SnipKeep > Uninstall.
2. Removes the app, Start menu entry and startup entry. Asks whether to keep settings. Never deletes screenshots.

Spec sheet

SnipKeep is a C# WinForms app on .NET Framework 4.8, which ships inside Windows 10 (1903+) and 11. That keeps the exe under 300 KB with nothing extra to install.

Item	Choice	Why
Language / UI	C#, WinForms	Native look, small, no runtime download
Runtime	.NET Framework 4.8	Built into Windows 10 1903+ and 11
Clipboard watch	`AddClipboardFormatListener` on a hidden window	Event-driven, 0% CPU when idle. Replaces the 500 ms polling in the script
Single instance	Named mutex + named event	Second launch tells the first to show settings, then exits
Settings	`%APPDATA%\SnipKeep\settings.json`	Easy to read, back up and delete
Start with Windows	`HKCU\...\CurrentVersion\Run` value "SnipKeep"	Shows as SnipKeep in Task Manager. No admin
Alerts	Short-lived notification icon, errors only	Toast header shows "SnipKeep" with our icon. Nothing stays in the tray
Installer	Inno Setup, per-user, `%LOCALAPPDATA%\Programs\SnipKeep`	No admin prompt. Registers in Settings > Apps. Asks a running copy to quit (`--quit`) before update and uninstall
Build and release	GitHub Actions on `windows-latest` , triggered by a version tag	Every release is built the same way, from source
License	All rights reserved, with an "as is" no-warranty clause	Keeps every option open, including selling later. Can move to open source later



The top row runs on every clipboard change. The bottom row runs only when the user opens SnipKeep.

Screenshots-only rule

A clipboard update counts as a screenshot when it holds a bitmap and none of these formats: `HTML Format`, `FileDrop`, `Rich Text Format`, or Office drawing formats. Content marked `ExcludeClipboardContentFromMonitorProcessing` (used by password managers) is never saved, even with the setting off. Browsers and Office add those when you copy an image. Snip & Sketch does not. This rule must be checked on real Windows 10 and 11 machines before release.

Settings file

Key	Default
`folder`	`%USERPROFILE%\Pictures\Screenshots`
`namePattern`	`Screenshot {yyyy-MM-dd HH.mm.ss}`
`screenshotsOnly`	true
`startWithWindows`	true
`paused / pausedUntil`	false / empty
`firstSaveShown`	false. Set after the one-time "First screenshot saved" toast

Name clashes in the same second get `(2)`, `(3)` and so on. Characters Windows does not allow are removed from the pattern.

Performance budgets

Measure	Budget
Snip to file on disk	under 1 s for a 4K screenshot
Memory, idle	under 30 MB
CPU, idle	0%
App startup	under 0.5 s
Exe / installer size	under 300 KB / under 2 MB

Release, testing and risks

v1.0 ships as a GitHub Release with two files: `SnipKeep-Setup.exe` and `SnipKeep-portable.zip`. The repo gets a README with a demo GIF, this PRD under `docs/`, and the old script moved to a `legacy/` folder.

Release steps

1. Build the app and installer in GitHub Actions.
2. Asher runs the test checklist on his Windows 10 PC.
3. Fix, tag `v1.0.0`, publish the release.
4. Add SnipKeep to the portfolio site and pin the repo.

Test checklist

- ☐ Install with no admin prompt
- ☐ First run asks for the folder, default is Pictures\Screenshots
- ☐ 20 snips in a row: 20 files, none missed, no duplicates
- ☐ Image copied from Chrome: not saved when Screenshots only is on
- ☐ Image copied from Word: not saved when Screenshots only is on
- ☐ Pause, snip, resume: snip during pause not saved
- ☐ Restart Windows: SnipKeep running, shows as "SnipKeep" in Task Manager > Startup
- ☐ Open from Start menu while running: settings window, no second copy
- ☐ Folder deleted while running: error toast, click opens settings
- ☐ Uninstall: app, Start menu and startup entry gone, screenshots kept
- ☐ Idle memory under 30 MB after 1 hour

Risks

Risk	Impact	Plan
Unsigned exe shows "Windows protected your PC"	Users may not trust it	README explains "More info > Run anyway". Consider paid code signing later (free SignPath signing needs an open source license)
Antivirus flags an unknown app that reads the clipboard	Install blocked	Public source code, built by GitHub Actions. Submit to Microsoft for review if flagged
Screenshots-only rule misses or blocks some images	Wrong files saved or skipped	Test on Windows 10 and 11. Setting can be turned off
Windows 11 Snipping Tool already auto-saves	Less need on 11	Position as Windows 10 first. On 11 it still adds folder choice and naming
Claude cannot run Windows builds directly	Bugs found late	Build in GitHub Actions. Asher tests each build

Decisions (Nov 3, 2026)

- Name: SnipKeep. The only exact match found is a small, inactive code-snippet repo. A paid macOS app called SnapKeep exists, so always say "for Windows" in the README and store text.
- Repo renamed from `pc-screenshot-saver` to `snipkeep`.
- License: all rights reserved, with an "as is" no-warranty clause. Replaces MIT so a paid version stays possible.
- Default folder: `Pictures\Screenshots`, plus a one-time toast on the first save. Desktop was rejected because OneDrive often syncs it and it fills up fast.